



BRILL

ARIES – JOURNAL FOR THE STUDY
OF WESTERN ESOTERICISM 24 (2024) 231–235



ARIES
brill.com/aries

Definition as (De)colonial Weapon

Western Esotericism Meets Islamic Occultism and Is Weirded Out

Matthew Melvin-Koushki

University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC, USA

mmelvink@sc.edu

Although Engler and Gardiner appear unaware of my project—the decolonization of Western intellectual and imperial history with the weirdly useful and usefully weirding weapon that is Islamic occultism—I find it resonates well with this, their rousing grammatological manifesto for interpretationist, elucidative *utility* in the study of esotericism. Following in the footsteps of the grammatologists of yore, they semiologically marry all opposites in the quest to transcend the prison of binaries, in this case religionism vs. historicism, both of which sever semantic networks: this impasse must be exploded to make the very term “esotericism” a useful, expansive, cosmopolitan virtue rather than a divisive, restrictive, ghettoizing vice. But they do not here take the further step of transcending the academy itself to acknowledge the *political* impacts of our definitions, the raw and real-world violence our stories help spawn or do nothing to quell.

The same goes for the word “Western”: in an era of Euro-American global colonial hegemony, this western European Renaissance fiction become modern imperial fact must be deconstructed at all costs, to stanch rampant and ongoing historicide, engine of genocide and ecocide alike. My basic arguments—explicitly utilitarian, yet also historically grounded and philologically rigorous—for Islam as the “Greater West” and for “Islamic occultism” as integral to Western history of philosophy, science and technology are therefore designed as strategic deconstructions of the still-pandemical triumphalist textbook narrative of “the West and the Rest.” Yet in this manifesto they are alluded to in passing as apparently uselessly essentialist.

To the contrary, as I have often stated, I *loosely* use “esotericism” as a sociological term and “occultism” as an epistemological one simply for their natural utility in American English: my undergraduate students reliably associate the first with “secrecy” and the second with “magic.” This usage likewise comes from listening closely to my early modern Muslim thinkers and doers, all vocif-

erously anti-secretive, popularizing imperial philosophers and practitioners of the occult sciences as simply good and indeed revolutionary, paradigm-shifting mathematical-natural science, who occupied the same sociopolitical niche that Silicon Valley does today. The “de-esotericization of occultism” is thus a usefully understandable description of a defining feature and driver of the early modern transformations that swept the Afro-Eurasian ecumene and the central focus of my work as a historian of science and empire. Similarly, I play with obviously anachronistic and fraught concepts like “occult democracy,” “geomantic googling” and “Islamic animism” as useful stumblingblocks: for *playing with stumblingblocks*, in my experience, is more efficient at getting the semiological and political job done in one fell swoop.

By the same token, Hanegraaff’s definition of esotericism as rejected knowledge is irrelevant to my early modern Persianate context—yet wonderfully useful for explaining why my often hugely influential actors and sources have been brazenly written out of history, and why Muslim bodies and books are being burnt today at a scale never before seen. The stuff Melvin-Koushki finds interesting—and ethically imperative—is precisely those *types of knowledge rejected by the modern constitution, simultaneously Protestant, colonialist and Orientalist, and openly Inquisitorially, witchhungrily Islamophobic*. Islamic occultism as Western science and empire gets at the guts of these currents of violence and disrupts them at their source; it forces us to stay with the trouble and *make new oddkin*.

“Esotericism” thus makes an excellent stumblingblock too. But to use this Latinate term as a master category, however emically and etically ever-shifting, also comes with Eurocentric dangers by definition, around which Engler and Gardiner seek to chart a path. Most dangerous is its strong association with initiatory secrecy as a primary meaning in English, which, while useful for comparative study, has as its historiographical wellspring the peculiar sociopolitical circumstances of early modern Latin Christendom, insular and infamously persecutory. In the far vaster, wealthier, more populous and more cosmopolitan contemporary Islamic world, encompassing a full *two-thirds of the human race* by the sixteenth century and just as fully committed to *Hellenic-Abrahamic dialectics*, the same will to persecution was comparatively rare and much less deadly—so this definition of esotericism has utility more in contrast.

As an Islamicist trained in the Franco-German Orientalist tradition, however, I can testify that the original sin of Islamic Studies (to say nothing of “Middle East” Studies!) is its magnetic attraction to and obsession with a tiny handful of medieval Muslim anti-occultist polemicists as colonialist proof for the superstition of the religionbound natives. Egregiously, that colonialist,

Enlightened, all-too-Protestant obsession with exorcizing Islam continues to be institutionally all-structuring in ways unthinkable and hence invisible to Europeanists and critical theorists.

A case in point is Saif's definition of "Islamic esotericism" as *bāṭiniyya*. Engler and Gardiner rightly critique this artificial substantive as rigid, religionist and exclusionary; what they are not in a position to note is that its immediate semantic network is also exclusively polemical. Historically and grammatically, it encodes the medieval "Isma'ili conspiracy" discourse as a collective, theologico-political term for "subversive esotericists worthy of death" and hence targets of state violence. The successive apocalypses of climate change, Mongol conquest and Black Death changed everything, however; from the late fourteenth century onward such polemics died away in the face of the Islamo-Afro-Eurasian ascendancy of occult science as a primary imperial-cum-popular means of empirically exploring and controlling the world. Such blatantly polemical categories became irrelevant as partisans of the *bāṭin*—a wonderfully fluid word meaning something like *mind-heart-guts-pith-spirit-sanctum-secret-unseen-occult*—boomed from the Atlantic Ocean to the Indian and the Pacific. To divide and conquer Islamo-Afro-Eurasia, Anglo-Franco-Russian colonialism made a strategic deal with the Puritan Devil to reanimate that zombie polemic for historicidal, genocidal and ecocidal purposes of its own.

Given the difficulty of decolonizing the Latinate term "esotericism," and the persistent Eurocentric, Orientalist and polemical taint of "bāṭinism" in medievalizing Euro-American scholarship, what if we were to dodge this double bullet by taking as our master category for comparative study an equally ubiquitous but more valorizing Arabo-Persian one instead, thereby actually provincializing Latinate Europe, the Lesser West?

Enter the *Islamic Weird*. Throughout the highly networked post-Mongol, early modern Islamic world, partisans of the *gharīb*—another wonderfully fluid word meaning something like *strange-foreign-alien-odd-difficult-rare-valuable-elite-precious-paranormal-uncanny-fated-synchronicitous-ominous-portentious-dangerous-traumatic-shocking-amazing-breathhtaking-ravishing-enchanting-magical-wondrous* and above all *weird*, in its encompassing, psychedelic Old English sense—also boomed from the Atlantic Ocean to the Indian and the Pacific. It became a universal term of both science and art generally, and definitive of the occult sciences specifically, those "sciences of the weird" (*ulūm gharība*) par excellence, and matrices of East-West and West-East translation. From astrology to alchemy, from medicine to minerology, from painting to poetry, from architecture to engineering, from boozing to battling, from political theory to natural history, from theology to law, the will to *won-*

der at the weird and the Other (human or otherwise) came to inform virtually every aspect of Islamo-Afro-Eurasian epistemologies and sociologies as a primary crosscultural, transhuman and transspecies comparativist ethos. (We're well beyond the Wunderkammer now!) Wondrously enough, rhyming spells like *quantum weirdness*, *high weirdness* and *the Superhumanities* bid fair to do the same today.

Engler and Gardiner's programmatic call for more valuable (not truer) and more usefully fluid definitions of "esotericism" does much to offset the problems created by the historically exclusionary and Eurocentric nature of the word itself. These definitions are still bedeviled by a lack of political utility, however, so are unlikely to help save premodern or modern bodies or books from the pyre. But to Weird the West is to undo Euro-American imperial demonology, is to tell stories more medicinal because more decolonially, well, *gharib*.

Bibliography

- Davis, E., *High Weirdness: Drugs, Esoterica and Visionary Experience in the Seventies*, Cambridge: MIT Press 2019.
- Engler, S., and M.Q. Gardiner, '(Re)defining *Esotericism*: Fluid Definitions, Property Clusters and the Cross-Cultural Debate', *Aries* 24:2 (2024), 151–207.
- Ford, P. and J.F. Martel, *Weird Studies*, podcast, <https://www.weirdstudies.com>.
- Hanegraaff, W.J., *Esotericism and the Academy: Rejected Knowledge and Western Culture*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press 2012.
- Haraway, D.J., *Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene*, Durham, NC: Duke University Press 2016.
- Kripal, J.J., *The Superhumanities: Historical Precedents, Moral Objections, New Realities*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press 2022.
- Melvin-Koushki, M., 'Early Modern Persian', in *Translating Esotericisms*, ed. W.J. Hanegraaff and M. Mukhopadhyay, special issue, *Correspondences* 11:1 (2023), 103–112.
- Melvin-Koushki, M., 'An Islamic Scientific Revolution? Early Modern Occult Science, Cosmic Philology and the Weird', special roundtable issue, ed. Justin Stearns and Nahyan Fancy, *History of Science* 61:2 (2023), 166–172.
- Melvin-Koushki, M., 'Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?' *Theology and Science* 18, no. 2 (2020), 303–324.
- Melvin-Koushki, M., 'Magic in Islam between Religion and Science', *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 14:2 (2019), 255–287.
- Melvin-Koushki, M., 'Taḥqīq vs. Taqlīd in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity', *Philological Encounters* 3:1–2 (2018), 193–249.

- Melvin-Koushki, M., 'Of Islamic Grammatology: Ibn Turka's Lettrist Metaphysics of Light', *al-Uṣūr al-Wuṣṭā: Journal of Middle East Medievalists* 24 (2016), 42–113.
- Zadeh, T., *Wonders and Rarities: The Marvelous Book That Traveled the World and Mapped the Cosmos*, Cambridge: Harvard University Press 2023.